

- ▶ A capacitive touch-based display with four or more contact points and support for only two possible resolutions, 800 x 480 (WVGA) and 480 x 320 (HWVGA)
- ▶ An accelerometer

Each of these components reads like the description of a dedicated gaming device. And every single one of these components is inside of your phone. From a hardware perspective, then, Windows Phone is a great gaming platform. It provides the features developers want, but is also a consistent target for developers since the hardware support is universal across devices. With Windows Mobile, there were so many processor architectures, so many CPU clock speeds, so many screen resolutions and other differences, that making even a simple game run properly across devices was almost impossible. On Windows Phone, it's not just possible, it's easy, and since the basic hardware requirements are so high-end, developers won't need to cater to the lowest common denominator.

It gets better. Developers will be able to more easily port existing PC and Xbox 360 games to Windows Phone. They'll be able to write games that work on all three systems. And they'll even be able to write certain classes of games where gamers can compete against each other from different platforms. In the beginning, this interaction will occur only between Windows Phone and Windows-based PCs. But it will be extended to the Xbox 360 over time.

The key to this gaming interaction between Windows Phone, Windows and the Xbox 360 is an evolving software stack that's present in Windows Phone, on Windows PCs and on the Xbox 360 console. It includes three key pieces:

- ▶ **Silverlight:** Essentially an application framework and runtime environment based on *Microsoft's .NET* managed code libraries, Silverlight is also the basis for the Windows Phone OS. So when developers create Windows Phone applications, they do so in Silverlight. And many games, especially casual games, will be written within this environment as well. Some portability exists between Windows Phone apps and the Silverlight environment Microsoft has created for Windows and the Web.
- ▶ **XNA:** The most advanced and capable Windows Phone games will be written with the XNA technologies, which include a framework and runtime environment, also based on *.NET* but optimized for 2-D and 3-D gaming, and an integrated development tool called XNA Game Studio. XNA games can target Windows Phone, Windows and Xbox 360 (as well as the Zune HD),